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# Bilingual Parenting as Good Parenting: Parents' Perspectives on Family Language Policy for Additive Bilingualism

Kendall King [a] & Lyn Fogle [a]

[a] Department of Linguistics, Georgetown University, Washington, D.C., USA

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# Bilingual Parenting as Good Parenting: Parents' Perspectives on Family Language Policy for Additive Bilingualism

***Kendall King and Lyn Fogle***
*Department of Linguistics, Georgetown University, Washington, D.C., USA*

**This paper investigates how parents explain, frame and defend their particular family language policies. We focus here on 24 families who are attempting to achieve additive Spanish–English bilingualism for their children, an aim which in many cases requires parents to use and to teach a language that is not their first language, nor the primary language of the home or wider community. We explore how parents make these decisions; how parents position themselves relative to 'expert' advice and other members of their extended families; and how these decisions are linked to their identities as 'good' parents. Our data suggest that parents draw selectively from expert advice and popular literature, using it to bolster their decisions in some cases while rejecting it in others. Extended families, in contrast, generally were raised in the interview discourse as points of (negative) contrast. Overall, we find that parents primarily relied on their own personal experiences with language learning in making decisions for their children. Our data further suggest that family language policies for the promotion of additive bilingualism have become incorporated into mainstream parenting practices, but also that these parents' efforts could be better supported.**

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**Keywords:** additive bilingualism, childhood bilingualism, elite bilingualism, English, family language policy, parental ideologies, Spanish

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A growing number of parents in the USA and elsewhere view bilingualism as a laudable personal and family goal and strive to provide their children with the opportunity to learn a second language at a young age. One clear measure of this parental desire to promote child bilingualism is the explosive demand for and development of two-way bilingual education programmes, in which both majority-language and minority-language children learn two languages (Center for Applied Linguistics, 2005). Concomitantly, as further evidence of this trend, recent years have seen a dramatic increase in the production of CDs, videos, flash cards and books geared at babies or toddlers and marketed at parents who want their children to acquire a second language. This sort of additive bilingualism has traditionally been viewed as the purview of upper class 'elites'. Indeed, 'additive bilingualism' (Lambert, 1975) and 'elite bilingualism' (Fishman *et al*., 1966) are sometimes used as synonyms (e.g. McCarty, 1995) to refer to contexts where families *choose* to maintain and

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develop two or more languages. Our data suggest that incorporation of language enrichment, additive approaches into child-rearing practices has also become common among 'non-elites' as well.

This trend represents a marked departure from previous decades for both language-minority and language-majority parents. Bilingual parenting – like toddler maths, art and music classes, baby sign language instruction and infant gym classes – are now commonplace in middle class circles (Piller, 2005). Many language-majority parents are no longer satisfied by traditional high-school level, foreign-language approaches and are eager to provide language enrichment activities for children at a young age. (Indeed, demand for two-way bilingual programmes is often most intense among English-speaking parents [Montague, 2000].) Language-minority parents, in turn, are increasingly vocal about desires for their children to maintain their first language and more assertive about educational rights and opportunities to do so as indicated, for instance, by the growing number of heritage language programmes for Spanish speakers (Peyton *et al*., 2001).

Nevertheless, for both groups, raising children who become competent, active uses of two languages – at least up to the present – has remained the exceptional case in the USA. Children from a wide variety of backgrounds most typically become English-dominant if not English monolingual by middle to late childhood (Wong Fillmore, 2000). Even within families adhering to the so-called one-person-one-language (OPOL) strategy, children often become passive (receptive) rather than active (productive) bilinguals (Döpke, 1992, 1998; Yamamoto, 1995). In explanation, researchers point to the high status of English (Tuominen, 1999; Wong Fillmore, 2000); national and local language policies that fail to support non-English languages (Spolsky, 2004); the lack of high quality bilingual education (Zentella, 1997); and the role of peers and siblings (Shin, 2002), among other factors.

Given the many challenges to raising bilingual children in the USA, how do parents attempting to meet this ambitious goal understand, explain and defend their decisions? In other words, how do they come to establish their 'family language policies', that is, what we mean here to be *overt* (Schiffman, 1996), *explicit* (Shohamy, 2006) decisions about how language is allocated within family communication. Such family language policy decisions merit careful investigation as the linguistic, psychological and emotional stakes for both children and parents are high. Family language policies of course potentially impact children's bilingual development and Piller (2002), for example, has shown how the quest for 'perfectly balanced' bilingual children can result in both parental disappointment and children's sense of failure.

Family language policies, like all language policies, are shaped by – and thus also encompass – beliefs and ideas about language (Spolsky, 2004). One potentially important source of input for parents in establishing family language policy is the increasingly prevalent parenting literature and popular press (Krafchick *et al*., 2005). Indeed, parenting books now represent the largest category of 'self-help' resources (Norcross *et al*., 2000). While the quality and accuracy of these publications is questionable (Rosen [1993], for instance, found that over 95% lacked any empirical base for their claims), Tovares (2005) reports that parents (and in particular, middle-class parents

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[see Lareau, 2003]) actively incorporate expert advice on parenting from literature and childcare professionals into everyday parenting practices. Likewise, Okita (2001: 142–143) describes first- or second-hand information from bilingual advice books as instrumental in the formation of a 'pro-activist' mothering style, that is a child-centred, minority-language focused and pedagogically oriented approach to mothering.

Parents' language policy decisions are also inextricably connected with other aspects of parenthood, including culture-specific notions of what makes a 'good' or 'bad' parent, mother or father. In this way, public discourse regarding ('good' or 'bad') parenting thus also potentially influences parental beliefs and practices. In an analysis of a family literacy television series in Great Britain, for example, Pitt (2002) found that mothers participating in the project changed their conceptions of what it meant to be a 'good mother', incorporating ideals promoted by the programme into daily household activities. Okita (2001), in turn, describes how the 'good mother' identities of Japanese mothers (living in England with English spouses) were vulnerable to unrelenting public advice and recommendations, and concomitant little recognition of the (invisible) work that bilingual parenting entailed, often resulting in maternal guilt, stress and personal trauma.

Other studies, in contrast, note the limitations of public discourse on parenting. This research highlights the fact that more private or intimate sources, such as family and friends, provide key advice and support in decision-making. Mitchell and Green (2002), for instance, find that female kinship networks in a working class London community were closely intertwined with new mothers' identities. Similarly, Madge and O'Connor (2004) argue that while many British mothers relied on the internet as a non-judgemental site for identity formation and practical advice, 'off-line' support systems of family and health professionals were still important to these women.

In establishing family language policy then, both personal networks and public discourses on parenting potentially come into play. For instance, mothers who are raising their children bilingually may have their identities as 'good mothers' called into question as bilingual child-rearing is viewed as unusual in many communities, and in some recent court cases, even illegal (*Los Angeles Times*, 2005); conversely, one might be considered a 'bad mother' by family members, especially those residing outside the USA, for not teaching the child the heritage language before or with English. This paper examines how parents draw on a variety of sources, including popular literature, expert advice, friends and family members, as well as their own personal language learning histories, in explaining and justifying their family language policies. We show that parents draw from each of these sources in different ways in order to construct themselves as 'good parents'. We illustrate how parents, and mothers in particular, discursively position themselves both with and against the advice and opinions of others in framing their 'good-parenting' decisions. While in many communities fathers play an increasingly visible and active role in parenting, the brunt of the work of parenting (Thompson, 1991) and the bulk of the expectations still fall disproportionately on mothers' shoulders

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(Bunnell & Beutler, 1999). For this reason, we focus primarily (but not exclusively) on mothers here.

## Methods

### Data collection

Twenty-four families participated in audio-recorded, ethnographic interviews for the study. In most cases, mothers only were interviewed although in six instances both parents participated. While parents were given a choice to conduct the interview in English or Spanish, all chose English. Parents were recruited through two venues with the aim of reaching a diverse group: (1) an announcement was posted on a popular parenting listserv designed to provide a 'support group' for new parents in the Washington metropolitan area; (2) a flyer was distributed to students at a city pre-K and elementary charter school offering a bilingual Montessori curriculum. Parents who responded to the recruitment notices were asked to complete a short questionnaire to determine eligibility. Eligible parents had a least one child under five in the home whom they explicitly aimed to raise Spanish–English bilingual.

All of the interviews covered a similar set of topics. Parents were asked to begin by talking about the goals for their children's language development. The conversation then turned to the strategies to meet those goals, their children's language exposure and proficiencies, as well as the parents' beliefs about language learning. Parents were encouraged to follow issues and angles of particular interest to them. Many delved into other areas of parenting as well as how their positions had developed over time. The interviews, which mostly took place in family living rooms or kitchens, had a relaxed and conversational tone.

### Participants

All 24 participating families lived in the Washington D.C. metropolitan area. As evident in Table 1, fathers tended to be older and slightly less educated than mothers. Nevertheless, only 10 of the mothers were employed out of the home in full-time jobs, while all but two of the fathers were. As only about 30% of US adults in the North-east in this age group have completed under-

**Table 1** Participants' mean ages, education levels and employment

| | | *Mothers* | *Fathers* |
|---|---|---|---|
| Age | Mean | 34.7 | 37 |
| | Range | 35–44 | 26–56 |
| Education level | Four-year college | 23/24 | 19/24 |
| | Post-graduate | 14/24 | 13/24 |
| Employment | Full-time | 10/24 | 22/24 |

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graduate degrees (US Census, 2004), our sample is very well educated relative to the total population (with 96% of mothers and 79% of fathers reportedly holding college degrees). Nevertheless, a minority of the parents fit the image of 'elite bilinguals', with more than one third holding down traditional working and solidly middle class jobs in the fields of public school teaching, nursing and carpentry (see the Appendix), while also residing in working class areas of the city.

Seventeen families had only one child (with a mean age of about three years), and seven had two children. Three of the mothers were not living with the father of their children. Half of the families were 'mixed' with one non-Latino parent and one Latino parent (although not all parents who identified as Latino were Spanish dominant). Four of the mothers were African-American and one was Korean-American. None of the participants were members of same-gendered unions/households.

Home language practices defy easy categorisation (De Houwer, 1999; Juan-Garau & Pérez-Vidal, 2001; Romaine, 1995; Tuominen, 1999). At the risk of oversimplifying, families' language practices fell into five different types, ranging on a continuum from most English-oriented to most Spanish-oriented (see Table 2). At one end of the continuum were families in which both parents were native speakers of English and who attempted to incorporate Spanish into children's home, school and/or social life (seven families). Further along the continuum were parents who were both native English speakers, but one parent spoke mostly or only Spanish with the child(ren) (two families). Next were parents who had different native languages and used both at home with each other but attempted to maintain OPOL (nine families), or who mixed languages with their children (two families). At the far end were Spanish-fluent parents (most but not all of whom were native speakers) who used mostly or only Spanish at home and attempted to incorporate English into their children's social or academic life (four families).

**Table 2** Language practice in the home

| *Type* | *Number of families* | *Description* |
|---|---|---|
| Both parents native English speakers | 7 | Spanish is generally not spoken in the home |
| | 2 | One parent speaks Spanish in the home to the child |
| One parent is native speaker of Spanish | 9 | One parent is designated to speak Spanish (OPOL) to child |
| | 2 | Both parents speak both languages to the child |
| Both parents Spanish fluent | 4 | Spanish spoken in the home |

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### Data analysis

Interviews were transcribed using a standardised format. Following grounded theory protocol (Strauss, 1987; Strauss & Corbin, 1990), we reviewed each interview for meaningful, relevant discourse units (phrases, sentences or longer expressive units), grouped and then coded these into approximately 30 conceptual categories. These codes were created, expanded and refined throughout the multiple rounds of coding so that they emically 'fit' the data. Using FileMakerPro 6, a database was created so that each coded discourse unit was logged as an individual record, together with background information concerning the speaker (e.g. first, second and third languages, education level, place of birth, and age and gender of child[ren]). A total of 1113 records were created through this process. This system allowed us to collectively review discourse on a wide range of topics systematically, to compare discourse on similar topics across speakers and speaker-groups, and to identify recurrent themes across the conversations.

We focus here primarily on qualitative description of how parents' discursively construct their initial parenting decisions concerning language use in the home. We chose not to focus on children's linguistic development or the interaction between children's preferences or competencies and parental strategies, although we of course recognise that family language policies and practices are dynamic and interactionally negotiated (e.g. Lanza, 2004; Tuominen, 1999). We made this decision in part because parents did not raise this as a major concern (perhaps in part due to the children's relatively young age, with more than half under 36 months), but more importantly, because our primary aim here was to provide detailed description of how parents initially establish their family language goals and policies during the first years of parenthood.

## Explaining Family Language Policy for Additive Bilingualism

All parents saw bilingualism as an advantage and discussed its benefits – ranging from maintenance of cultural ties to increased economic opportunities – for their children. And all parents had explicitly discussed and decided to use two languages with their children from a young age. As these decisions were established at the outset of the interviews, the remainder of the conversations allowed parents to revisit and reconstruct decision-making related to their family's language policy. Although many parents voiced uncertainties about raising their child bilingually, particularly around the issues of language delay, confusion and effective teaching practices (see King & Fogle, 2006), parents took the interview as an opportunity to explain their personal decisions in light of these concerns. Parents drew from three main sources in defending and explaining their bilingual parenting decisions: (1) the popular press and parenting advice literature, (2) other bilingual families, particularly those of their extended family and (3) their personal experiences with language learning. In numerical terms, parents referred to each of these sources about equally: across the interviews, there were 52 mentions of expert advice or information on child bilingualism; 31 references to other families'

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language practices; and 43 discussions of parents' personal experiences with language learning. However, the *ways* in which parents used these sources to provide support for their decisions and stances differed considerably. Below we analyse how parents' concomitant acceptance and rejection of advice and opinion were used in the construction of their own family language policy decisions as 'good' parenting.

### 'I know that studies show...'

Many parents referred to magazines, newspapers or research findings as informing their family's language policy. In most cases, these references were general citations of popular literature beginning with what Tovares (2005) terms 'vague openers', such as 'I've read' or 'I know from the research'. Within parental discourse these openers serve to assign more weight to parents' stated choices (Tovares, 2005), and indeed, parents often employed these vague openers as they discussed their decisions and rationales. A particularly salient example of this was parents' reference to popular articles that touted the cognitive or academic benefits of childhood bilingualism (e.g. *Los Angeles Times*, 2002). Citations of this research provided support for parents' decisions to raise their children bilingually, and to this end, claims of cognitive benefits seemed to be appropriated and even expanded by parents:

> **Melanie:** I also read somewhere, and this was before we decided to raise them bilingual, that uhm it helps abstract reasoning, so I saw that as certainly an advantage, raising them bilingual.
>
> **Susan:** It appears that from the studies of different books that I read, it appears that kids who, the earlier they're taught [two languages], the more intelligent they are. [...] They seem to have a broader range of different things. It's like they use more of their brain to process.
>
> **Elizabeth:** Yeah, I read some article in the newspaper. Uh, like I read in the newspaper some study done in London or I don't remember where. And they said that after the studies they made, they discovered that it's better for the development [of the child].
>
> **Mimi:** Everything that I have read says that it's only going to make him smarter, and you know they're better at Math and more appreciative of other cultures and I really, really want that for him.
>
> **Molly:** There's so much research and so much studies that say that your brain just expands a lot more, you're able, you're like smarter because you're able to learn things in different languages, and your brain is just, you know, develops a lot better and stuff.

Further, parents like Maribel (below), who grew up speaking both Spanish and English in the USA, reported employing this popular literature and expert advice to counter family members' concerns:

> **Maribel:** Probably the only resistance we got was from my husband's father at one point. He was like, is it going to delay their English skills? Uhm, and we said absolutely not. And we told him we had done some

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> research that showed it doesn't, and it says they can master both languages and that kids brains are just sponges, and they can pick up everything.

Research or expert-based justifications and explanations were used to support other, more specific decisions as well. For instance, many parents cited professional or popular literature as supporting their decision to expose the child to both languages early on and believed that second language learning is always easier and more effective at a young age (also see Okita, 2002; Piller, 2001).

> **Raul:** I mean that's why we did it from infancy. I mean, what I know from having read about it is the earlier you get the sounds in, the better. So that's why, you know, hours old I was using Spanish with her to get the phonemes in.

While parents tended to believe that notions such as 'earlier is always better' were scientific facts (rather than points of debate and active research in the field, e.g. Hyltenstam & Abrahamsson, 2000; Marinova-Todd *et al*., 2000), they were also willing to acknowledge the lack of specific sources for this information, as Marisol, also a heritage Spanish learner, does below.

> **Marisol:** So. I'm sure that the research on language acquisition has just made more advancements, but the one thing I do know is that early on zero to three, I think zero to five, maybe, is when you learn. It's the easiest point at which you can learn language and a second language. So, that's all I know. I couldn't cite you any books or studies actually.

Indeed, while all of our parents used these sorts of 'vague openers', only seven cited a specific study or book that they had read. A noted exception to this trend was one mother, Janice, who held a Masters degree in Spanish Linguistics and found inspiration in a popular guide for bilingual parents.

> **Janice:** I joined a uhm listserv, bilingual family something or another, and reading the experience of those families uh there's a book, *Raising Children Bilingual*. I don't remember. Harding is the, yeah, right, and I looked at those studies, and uhm to see what made them successful. And I just said, you know what, I've got everything I need.

For Janice, a fluent but non-native speaker of Spanish, former public school teacher and single mom, the popular literature gave her the confidence to create a 'Spanish-only' language policy for her family, which she has maintained for nearly five years. At least in some cases then, this popular and advice literature seemed important not only in shaping and supporting family language policy, but also in defending parent choices to disapproving members of the wider family, and constructing themselves as 'good' and well informed parents.

### 'Not like my sister's kids...'

Current research on parenting (e.g. Mitchell & Green, 2002; O'Connor & Madge, 2004) indicates the importance of friendship and family networks in

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providing emotional and practical support. Yet in our data, these personal sources were often constructed as a negative point of comparison, that is, to highlight the type of parent they did *not* want to be. Many, for instance, disapprovingly mentioned their immediate or extended family's decisions to not raise their children bilingually.

> **Krista:** [My brother and sister-in-law] had asked my parents to try to teach her [my niece] Korean. And then like six months or a year later, they asked them to stop so, because they thought that she was getting confused. And so that was their decision. That's kind of how they approached the whole bilingual thing. Or how they responded to it. I guess they thought she was being delayed or something like that you know in her speech or maybe they feared that she would be. And uhm and so but regardless, but taking their experience into account, I don't care even if he is delayed in speech. I don't care.
>
> **Philip:** My sister for example, she lives in Allensville, and she has three kids, and they understand Spanish perfectly, but they don't speak it or they might speak a couple of words, and it's mostly because she has not enforced it, in our opinion, too much because her husband is a pilot so oftentimes she's alone, so maybe it's easier.
>
> **Patricia** (Philip's wife): And he's from Puerto Rico, and she's from Cuba, both native languages are Spanish, but they speak in English with their kids!
>
> **Melissa:** Yeah, I don't think it, for us I think it was just what it was going to be. I know I've got an uncle from Colombia and he refuses to let his children speak Spanish because it's a stigma... So I could see how somebody might feel that way in that situation, but here I think, well I don't think we ever discussed that he was going – I don't think it was an option not to raise him [bilingually].

The depictions of other families figured strongly in parents' statements of their goals for their own children. Instead of accepting the same fate as these 'negative' examples, our parents detected flaws in other families' approaches. Further, they suggested they would avoid these pitfalls by, for instance, rejecting fears of language delay or confusion (Krista); 'enforcing' Spanish language use (Patricia); and rejecting the stigmatised status of Spanish (Melissa). In this way, interviewees contrasted their own 'good parenting' against an unsuccessful example, and consequently, constructed their own parenting practices as 'better' than others, largely by prioritising Spanish language use.

### 'When I was little...'

The most pervasive (and persuasive) source of data in shaping family language policy were parents' personal experiences with bilingualism, biculturalism or second language learning. Although numerically mentions of personal experience (43 in total) did not outnumber mentions of research or advice articles (52), personal experience was given more weight overall within

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the discourse. For instance, parents used personal experiences as the basis for rejecting expert advice or for making decisions that differed from those of other parents. Further, personal experience tended to provide the primary rationale for raising their child bilingually, with research or family examples then provided as back-up, additional support. More specifically, parents framed their own experiences as critical in shaping their decisions (1) to raise their children bilingually, (2) to introduce the second language at an early age and (3) to use specific methods for teaching a second language.

For both majority and minority language parents, personal experiences in learning language shaped their goals for their children. Many felt that they had missed opportunities by not being exposed to their heritage language or a second language early in life. In some cases, such as Arabella, this sense of loss was a driving force in promoting additive bilingualism for her daughter:

> **Arabella:** My dad is Puerto Rican, but my mom is German and American, but when my dad came here it was during the time that like people assimilated. So he raised us speaking English only in the home, my sister and I. So I've realized that was – I know he was trying to do something good for us, but it actually turned out not so great. So I've had to do a lot of catch-up even to communicate with my family because most of, in his side, most of his family is still in Puerto Rico. So my goal, and for my husband it was the same, we wanted to make sure that she was raised bilingually so that she was bilingual and biliterate in English and Spanish.

Arabella rejects her father's approach and prioritises her own first-hand experience of the effects of a family-wide, English-only policy. Several other parents, such as Krista, whose parents failed to teach her Korean as a child, made similar statements. Similarly, many parents cited their own experiences learning two languages as reasons for starting at a young age with their own children. Participants who considered themselves fluent bilinguals, such as Kim, who grew up bilingual in Spanish and German and later learned English, felt that they had benefited from early exposure. She uses her personal experience to counter the notion that there might be problems associated with early bilingualism (in response to a question about the challenges in raising a bilingual child):

> **Kim:** I don't remember having problems, and I really learned Spanish in kindergarten. So I can't imagine that she'll have a lasting impact, psychological impact from it. Uhm, honestly I don't see other disadvantages like I don't feel like it affected me in any way. So of course, I'm drawing from my experience, so perhaps there are children who will have a different experience, but I haven't seen it.

Other parents who were unsure about their own language skills, such as Carol, an African-American mother who worked as a delivery room nurse, felt that starting their children earlier than they had themselves would be beneficial:

> **Carol:** I remember I was in French class, and I would try and speak the language, but I would think it in English, and translate it in my mind,

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> and then I would say it. But she doesn't go through that process. It's just natural. It's not like you have to think. Because that's where you pause, and you're like, 'Hmmm. Let me see.' She doesn't have to go through that process; it's more natural.

Parents also drew from their own experience concerning the best pedagogical approaches to learning a second language and tended to have very different ideas about second language learning processes and sub-skills. For instance, some parents loosely based their parenting approaches on the way they felt when they themselves had learned a second language including seeking 'total immersion' experiences or purchasing materials such as books and music (Ellen).

> **Ellen:** And I think language instruction is a little bit like an advertising campaign. It's getting the messaging there in different ways. And getting the message in there when they're not thinking about it. You know, by the time you have to go to school and learn it, it's not fun. And I've learned vocabulary through songs. I found Spanish rock music. I was like 18 or 20, and so I found that to be very effective.

More generally, parents seemed to prioritise personal experience as the basis for a belief and policy, and then worked to support that belief with reference to research or other families' experiences. Parents also discarded the professional or popular advice that conflicted with their own beliefs, personal experiences or situations. For instance, Amy rejects the 'one person one language' approach as unrealistic:

> **Amy:** I know all the studies that say, you know, one parent should speak English and the other one should only speak in the other language. I can't do that. It's just too exhausting, and so when he was born, initially I thought – why can't, you know, they say that's the way to do it and to not do it any other way.

We see that Amy (and other parents like her) base her rejection of this advice on her own evaluation of her situation and her sense of what is practical for her family. In addition, Amy seems to suggest that an alternative is possible, and the advice found in the literature is not authoritative in this case.

This tendency to selectively appropriate advice was also found in other domains. For instance, Patricia, a native Spanish speaker, knew she wanted to raise her child bilingually and was already doing so, as she explains: 'I posted a question on the [local area parenting] listserv, and I got a lot of responses. You know some fitted [with her own preferred strategy], and some were like ''Oh, your child's not going to learn English, and she's going to be at a disadvantage when she goes to kindergarten,'' [but] some were very, very good.' Patricia rejects the advice that does not support her preference and characterizes that which does as being 'very, very good'. Later in the interview she indicated that her decision to raise her child bilingually was originally a personal choice, and as she explained here, one which she later justified with research.

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> **Patricia:** And there's a lot of people around you that if they hear you talking to your child in Spanish, they come and say 'She doesn't understand any English, you know, how are you going to do this?', mostly family, 'how are you guys going to do this?' And we still get those comments. When I started getting those comments, I tried to do some research.

Patricia's statement illustrates the complicated relationship between personal experience, parenting advice literature and family members' opinions. Patricia's personal decision was influenced by her own experiences together with observations of other children who cannot speak Spanish (as noted in the previous section); however, when directly challenged by family members about her decisions, Patricia sought support from research (as portrayed in the popular press). Therefore, Patricia's own success in becoming bilingual, her observation of other families' attempts to raise bilingual children in the USA, her reaction to family members' challenges to her approach and her popular reading on childhood bilingualism all played a role in the decisions she made and the manner in which she portrayed herself in the interview. Thus, overall, parents based a range of bilingual parenting decisions and strategies, from starting with an early age of exposure to using a specific method, on their own experiences. Yet, as described here, parents also made use of external sources of information, in particular popular literature and other families' experiences, in forming and supporting their own decisions. In short, we find that parents selectively accept *and reject* expert advice, and their primary basis for decision-making seems heavily informed by their own personal experiences with language.

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## Conclusion

Our findings suggest that parents are not uncritical consumers of any one source of advice or information. Though they cite and acknowledge input from the popular press and parenting literature as well as from family networks, parents frame these external sources in terms of the beliefs they have formed as a result of their own personal experiences. Their own personal encounters with language learning – successful or unsuccessful – seem to serve as the primary motivator in opting for an additive or enrichment family language policy.

Given the parents' high levels of education and intense interest in this topic, as well as the findings of other researchers, we expected more parents to name specific sources of information. For instance, previous studies of bilingual parents found a level of awareness about research on bilingual parenting that led us to believe our parents would cite actual titles (although this may be due to the fact that Tuominen's [1999] parents were personal contacts from her university and Piller's [2002] were recruited primarily through an international bilingual family newsletter and listserv [as indicated in Piller, 2001]). Only seven of our parents named one specific book or article about bilingual parenting (these included a Thomas and Collier study and readings from a college linguistics class); four referred to one, unnamed newspaper article; the

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others used 'vague openers' and mentions of research. Perhaps related to this fact, many parents were unaware of how frequently children raised in bilingual homes become active users of only one language.

Thus, while parents have a good deal of ammunition in terms of *reasons for* raising their children bilingual from both the popular press and their own experiences, they have relatively little information about the processes and *challenges of* raising bilingual children. This is in part due to the limited coverage of research on these processes in the popular press, while much of the research that does find its way into the popular press is superficial, exaggerated or inaccurate (King & Fogle, 2006). (And while there are myriad internet sites on this general topic, parents very rarely mentioned any of these sources.) It is also due to the basic fact that in many areas there are no clear-cut findings concerning, for instance, precisely how much of what types of exposure is needed to ensure children achieve something approaching balanced bilingualism. Many parents are thus left to rely on their own ideas about what worked for them or those promoted by corporations with a vested interested in selling commercial language learning materials, such as videos or computer programs. Only a few parents acknowledged the consistency and effort that is needed to support additive bilingualism, or seemed to have an inkling of the challenges ahead as their children entered their school years. For most families, the prospect of meeting their stated goals of raising their child 'fully bilingual' or 'perfectly fluent in two languages' seemed unrealistic, and likely to result in future disappointment in light of their current strategies and relevant research (e.g. Okita, 2001; Patterson, 2002; Pearson *et al*., 1997; Piller, 2001).

As parents explained and defended their family language policies, they concomitantly constructed themselves as 'good' parents who were committed to providing this opportunity for their children. Indeed parents often referred to bilingualism as a 'gift' that they wished to impart, and an important advantage for their children (also see Piller, 2001). This embrace of additive bilingualism for children has been characterised by some as part of the movement towards 'hyper-parenting', that is, the 'management of children's lives in pursuit of child success as a measure of parental achievement' (Piller, 2005). More generally, such an approach to parenting, common among middle and upper middle class US parents, is defined by parents' *concerted cultivation* of children's talents and skills (Lareau, 2003). We similarly find that our families' language policies are embedded in such a didactically oriented, early-enrichment-for-achievement parenting approach. (Indeed, the act of establishing an overt language policy implies a 'cultivation' approach to child-rearing.) However, our data also suggest that actively fostering what has been characterised as 'elite bilingualism' is now part of middle-class and mainstream parenting practices. Recall that parent participants in this study were well educated, but by no means were they all elite. Thus, promoting additive bilingualism, like promoting early math, early music and early movement skills, has become part of mainstream parenting (see Rosenfeld, 2005).

To what extent this holds true in other contexts and with other languages remains unclear as the findings from this study have limited generalisability.

All participants were residing in one (relatively) cosmopolitan US city, and most were speakers of two high-status world languages. Further, this study only provides a snap-shot of decision-making and reasons for those decisions at one, early phase in family life. No doubt myriad factors will intervene and family dynamics, policies and interactional patterns will shift over time (Felling, 2006; Okita, 2001). Lastly, all participants were self-selected and it is possible that those who chose to participate in these conversations with us were disproportionately thoughtful, proactive or critical about bilingual child-rearing.

This paper has attempted to tap into the relationship between public discourse, private networks and personal beliefs in influencing parenting practices in relation to language. Through an analysis of interview discourse with parents aiming to raise their children bilingually in English and Spanish, we have shown how this particular group of parents selectively appropriates advice and information from external sources that corroborate their own personal beliefs. However, much of the information that could support parents in their efforts is missing from the public discourse (King & Fogle, 2006) and not available through personal support networks. Parents could be better supported in terms of *techniques and approaches* with easier access to the existing and relevant research findings for parents (e.g. those which show that book reading is a more effective approach than video-viewing for very young second language learners [Patterson, 2002]); parents could also be better supported *emotionally* with more realistic expectations for child outcomes and more explicit recognition of the work involved in bilingual child-rearing (Okita, 2001). Lastly, while we as researchers could do more to popularly disseminate findings that are directly relevant to bilingual parenting, it is also important to continue to make the point (see Piller, 2001, 2005) that private language policy decisions are only one aspect of cultivating bilingualism. Actively advocating public language policy, and in particular public educational policy, that allow students of all ages to develop competencies in more than one language should not be left behind.

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## Correspondence

Any correspondence should be directed to Professor Kendall King, Department of Linguistics, Georgetown University, Intercultural Center 458, Washington, D.C. 20057, USA (akk25@georgetown.edu).

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## Appendix: Caregivers' self-reported professions

| *Mothers* | | | *Fathers* | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ***Family*** | ***Name*** | ***Profession*** | ***Name*** | ***Profession*** |
| 1 | Ellen | Sales and Marketing Consultant | Matthew | Marketing and Technology Consultant |
| 2 | Missy | Journalist | Paul | Photographer |
| 3 | Amy | Lobbyiest - International Affairs; Now Stay-at-home Mom | Bob | Commercial Real Estate |
| 4 | Kim | Principal in Management Consulting Firm | Jacob | Attorney |
| 5 | Marsha | Full-time Mom now; Law; International Relations | Timothy | Finance |
| 6 | Marisol | Attorney | Chuck | N/A |
| 7 | Kris | TV Documentary Producer | Caleb | Architect |
| 8 | Melissa | Legal Secretary | Earl | Chef |
| 9 | Cathy | Former Social Worker; Current Stay-at-home Mom | Raul | Psychologist |
| 10 | Krista | Communications | Cameron | Real Estate Development |
| 11 | Maribel | Physician's Assistant | Doug | Finance Manager |
| 12 | Elisa | Engineer | Arthur | Systems Engineer |
| 13 | Patricia | Attorney | Philip | Financial Analyst |
| 14 | Janice | Teacher | Assem | Computer Operator |
| 15 | Hope | Nursing School Full-time Student | Munroe | NGO |
| 16 | Isabel | Assistant Website Manager and Radio Producer | Derick | IT Manager |

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**Appendix** (*Continued*)

| *Mothers* | | | *Fathers* | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ***Family*** | ***Name*** | ***Profession*** | ***Name*** | ***Profession*** |
| 17 | Elizabeth | Artist | Don | Architect |
| 18 | Arabella | Executive Director, DC Charter School Association | Steven | Teacher |
| 19 | Margaret | Legal Office Support Staff; Lactation Counselor | Ricardo | Construction Worker |
| 20 | Melanie | Project Specialist in Economic Development | Edgar | Epidemiology |
| 21 | Molly | Consultant | Justin | Chief Engineer |
| 22 | Susan | Data Entry Clerk | Walter (great-grandfather) | Retired Upholsterer |
| 23 | Carol | Registered Nurse | Larry | Autopsy Assistant |
| 24 | Mimi | Stay-at-home Mom; Freelance Writer; Homeschool Teacher | Eugene | Accountant |

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